LT3209: SYNTAX

Effective Term
Semester A 2025/26

Part I Course Overview

Course Title
Syntax

Subject Code
LT - Linguistics and Translation

Course Number
3209

Academic Unit
Linguistics and Translation (LT)

College/School
College of Liberal Arts and Social Sciences (CH)

Course Duration
One Semester

Credit Units
3

Level
B1, B2, B3, B4 - Bachelor's Degree

Medium of Instruction
English

Medium of Assessment
English

Prerequisites
LT2201 Introduction to Linguistics, or LT2229 Fundamentals of Linguistics or LT2290 Introduction to Language Studies

Precursors
Nil

Equivalent Courses
CTL3209 Syntax

Exclusive Courses
Nil

Part II Course Details

Abstract

This course aims at enabling students to apply modern syntax frameworks to the analysis of language data and discover and formulate hypotheses that are observationally, descriptively and explanatorily adequate. Students will be able to evaluate different analyses for particular facts by providing syntactic argumentation and verifying their empirical predictions.

Course Intended Learning Outcomes (CILOs)

	CILOs	Weighting (if app.)	DEC-A1	DEC-A2	DEC-A3
1	Students will identify syntactic properties of lexical items in their role as the building blocks of phrases and clauses.		x	x	x
2	Students will analyze the basic structure of phrases and clauses and discover and formulate hypotheses that are observationally, descriptively and explanatorily adequate.		x	x	x
3	Students will determine whether particular examples observe general principles of grammar.		x	x	x
4	Students will learn to argue for or against a particular analysis.		x	x	x

A1: Attitude
Develop an attitude of discovery/innovation/creativity, as demonstrated by students possessing a strong sense of curiosity, asking questions actively, challenging assumptions or engaging in inquiry together with teachers.

A2: Ability
Develop the ability/skill needed to discover/innovate/create, as demonstrated by students possessing critical thinking skills to assess ideas, acquiring research skills, synthesizing knowledge across disciplines or applying academic knowledge to real-life problems.

A3: Accomplishments
Demonstrate accomplishment of discovery/innovation/creativity through producing /constructing creative works/new artefacts, effective solutions to real-life problems or new processes.

Learning and Teaching Activities (LTAs)

	LTAs	Brief Description	CILO No.	Hours/week (if applicable)
1	Lecture	Students will learn basic theoretical concepts in syntax.	1, 2, 3, 4	3 hours
2	Individual Reading	Students will read lecture notes and additional literature proposed by the instructor.	1, 2, 3, 4	
3	In-class Exercises	Students will practice applying concepts introduced in the lectures to the analysis of new data.	1, 2, 3, 4	

Assessment Tasks / Activities (ATs)

	ATs	CILO No.	Weighting (%)	Remarks ("-" for nil entry)	Allow Use of GenAI?
1	Assignments Students will complete two assignments.	1, 2, 3, 4	30	Students can use GenAI tools to brainstorm, gather information, solve problems, format references, and edit language. Students should give proper acknowledgment to all the content from GenAI tools that they incorporated into the assignment and keep a journal of their GenAI conversations. Students should not present texts generated or translated by GenAI tools as their own original work.	Yes
2	Mid-term quiz Students will demonstrate their understanding of the material discussed in the first half of the semester and apply their analytic skills in addressing issues and solving problems with new data.	1, 2, 3, 4	30	-	No
3	End-of-term test Students will demonstrate how well they have achieved the learning and teaching outcomes.	1, 2, 3, 4	40	-	No

Continuous Assessment (%)

100

Examination (%)

0

Examination Duration (Hours)
0

Assessment Rubrics (AR)

Assessment Task
1.Written assignments

Criterion
Demonstration of understanding of the nature of the problems and ability to solve novel syntax problems.

Excellent (A+, A, A-)
Demonstration of excellent understanding of the nature of the problems and ability to apply solutions for old problems to new ones.

Good (B+, B, B-)
Demonstration of good understanding of the nature of the problems and ability to apply solutions for old problems to new ones.

Fair (C+, C, C-)
Demonstration of fair understanding of the nature of the problems and ability to apply solutions for old problems to new ones.

Marginal (D)
Demonstration of basic understanding of the nature of the problems and ability to apply solutions for old problems to new ones.

Failure (F)
Little to no demonstration of understanding of the nature of the problems and ability to apply solutions for old problems to new ones.

Assessment Task
2. Mid-term quiz

Criterion
Demonstration of understanding of the key concepts in syntax introduced in the first half of the course and ability to solve novel syntax problems.

Excellent (A+, A, A-)
Demonstration of excellent understanding of the key concepts in syntax introduced in class and ability to solve novel syntax problems.

Good (B+, B, B-)
Demonstration of good understanding of the key concepts in syntax introduced in class and ability to solve novel syntax problems.

Fair (C+, C, C-)
Demonstration of fair understanding of the key concepts in syntax introduced in class and ability to solve novel syntax problems.

Marginal (D)
Demonstration of basic understanding of the key concepts in syntax introduced in class and ability to solve novel syntax problems.

Failure (F)

Little to no demonstration of understanding of the key concepts in syntax introduced in class and ability to solve novel syntax problems.

Assessment Task

3. End-of-term test

Criterion

Demonstration of understanding of the key concepts in syntax introduced in the entire class and ability to solve novel syntax problems

Excellent (A+, A, A-)

Demonstration of excellent understanding of the key concepts in syntax introduced in the entire class and ability to solve novel syntax problems.

Good (B+, B, B-)

Demonstration of good understanding of the key concepts in syntax introduced in the entire class and ability to solve novel syntax problems.

Fair (C+, C, C-)

Demonstration of fair understanding of the key concepts in syntax introduced in the entire class and ability to solve novel syntax problems.

Marginal (D)

Demonstration of basic understanding of the key concepts in syntax introduced in the entire class and ability to solve novel syntax problems.

Failure (F)

Little to no demonstration of understanding of the key concepts in syntax introduced in the entire class and ability to solve novel syntax problems.

Part III Other Information

Keyword Syllabus

Syntactic categories and their distributions: lexical categories, nouns, verbs, adjectives, prepositions, functional categories, determiners, case-markers, complementizers, inflectional morphology, morphological case, abstract Case, Case theory, the Case filter, agreement projection, theta-theory.
Phrase structure, structural, thematic and grammatical relations: X-bar theory, the projection principle, Merge, c-command, theta-roles, arguments, adjuncts, subject, object, indirect object, oblique, the extended projection principle, exceptional case marking.
Syntactic relations: anaphor and variable binding, negative polarity item licensing, A-movement, A-bar movement, antecedent-trace, chains, raising, control.
Levels of representation and their properties: D-structure, S-structure, Logical Form, Phonetic Form, abstract movement, quantifier raising, in-situ wh-phrases, multiple spell-out.
Constraints on movement and representations: syntactic islands, subjacency, the empty category principle, phase theory.

Reading List

Compulsory Readings

	Title
1	Carnie, Andrew. (2021). Syntax: A generative introduction (4th edition). Malden: Blackwell.
2	Lecture notes and in-class exercises.

Additional Readings

	Title
1	Radford, Andrew (2009). An introduction to English sentence structure. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
2	Everaert, Martin and Henk van Riemsdijk. (2006) (eds). The Blackwell companion to syntax. Volume 1-5. Oxford: Blackwell Publishing.
3	Tallerman, Maggie (2015). Understanding syntax. London/New York: Routledge.
4	Adger, David. 2003. Core syntax: A minimalist approach. Oxford: Oxford University Press.